

AZURE COST OPTIMIZATION · FINOPS

The Azure FinOps Cheat Sheet

15 Ways to Cut Your Azure Bill by 30%+

A field-tested playbook for IT and infrastructure leaders — eliminate cloud waste, right-size your commitments, and put real governance around spend, without compromising performance.

15 tactics · 4 pillars · a 30-day action plan

What's Inside

Fifteen high-ROI levers, grouped into four moves. Most need no re-architecture — start at the top and work down.

PILLAR 1 · COMMIT & LICENSE SMARTER

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|---|------------------------------------|---------------|
| 1 | Reserved Instances & Savings Plans | Up to ~72% |
| 2 | Azure Hybrid Benefit | 80%+ stacked |
| 3 | Spot Virtual Machines | Up to ~90% |
| 4 | Dev/Test Pricing & Subscriptions | Reduced rates |

PILLAR 2 · ELIMINATE WASTE

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|---|---------------------------------------|-------------------------|
| 5 | Right-Size Over-Provisioned Resources | Often the biggest win |
| 6 | Auto-Shutdown Idle Environments | ~65% of non-prod |
| 7 | Delete Orphaned Resources | Recurring monthly |
| 8 | Storage Lifecycle Tiering | Up to ~80% on cold data |

PILLAR 3 · SCALE EFFICIENTLY

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| 11 | Right-Tier PaaS Databases | Idle-time savings |
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PILLAR 4 · GOVERN & SUSTAIN THE SAVINGS

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| 14 | Work Advisor & Cost Management | Free, ongoing |
| 15 | Modernize to Serverless | Idle time is free |

PILLAR 1

Commit & License Smarter

The fastest savings on steady-state workloads — pay less for what you are already running.

1 Reserved Instances & Savings Plans

Up to ~72%

Commit to 1- or 3-year usage on predictable workloads (VMs, SQL, Cosmos DB). Azure Savings Plans for Compute give similar discounts with more flexibility across VM families and regions. Start with your always-on production baseline.

Watch out: Buy against your true steady-state floor, not your peak — over-committing locks in spend you will not use.

2 Azure Hybrid Benefit

80%+ stacked

Apply Windows Server and SQL Server licenses with Software Assurance to Azure VMs and SQL to drop the compute/license rate. Combined with Reserved Instances, savings on Windows VMs can reach 80%+.

Watch out: Track license entitlements so you stay compliant while you claim the benefit.

3 Spot Virtual Machines

Up to ~90%

Use Azure spare capacity for interruptible, stateless, or batch work — CI/CD runners, rendering, big-data jobs, dev sandboxes.

Watch out: Spot VMs can be evicted on short notice; use them only where a restart is cheap.

4 Dev/Test Pricing & Subscriptions

Reduced rates

Move dev, test, QA, and staging estates onto Azure Dev/Test subscriptions for reduced rates and waived per-hour Windows charges on eligible plans.

Watch out: Dev/Test subscriptions are for non-production use only — keep production separate.

PILLAR 2

Eliminate Waste

Stop paying for capacity nobody is using.

5 Right-Size Over-Provisioned Resources

Often the biggest win

Use Azure Advisor and Azure Monitor metrics to find VMs and databases running under 20% CPU/memory and step them down a size (or to a newer, cheaper series).

Watch out: Right-size against sustained load, not a one-off spike — keep headroom for real peaks.

6 Auto-Shutdown Idle Environments

~65% of non-prod

Schedule auto-shutdown (built into Azure VMs) or automation runbooks for dev/test/staging. A machine running 45 hrs/week instead of 168 costs about a third as much.

Watch out: Exclude anything that runs scheduled overnight jobs before you switch it off.

7 Delete Orphaned Resources

Recurring monthly

Sweep unattached managed disks, unassociated public IPs, stale snapshots, idle load balancers, empty App Service plans, and old NICs with Azure Resource Graph and Cost Management, then delete or archive.

Watch out: Confirm a resource is truly orphaned before deleting — check dependencies first.

8 Storage Lifecycle Tiering

Up to ~80% on cold data

Apply Blob lifecycle-management policies to auto-move data from Hot to Cool to Archive by age or last access.

Watch out: Archive has retrieval latency and cost — tier by how quickly you may need the data back.

PILLAR 3

Scale Efficiently

Match capacity to demand automatically, so you pay for load — not headroom.

9 Autoscale On Demand

Cuts off-peak spend

Use VM Scale Sets, App Service, and AKS autoscale with sensible min/max bounds, scaling on the metric that actually drives your load.

Watch out: Tune scale-in cooldowns so you do not thrash capacity up and down.

10 Optimize AKS & Containers

Reclaims cluster waste

Right-size pod requests/limits, enable the cluster autoscaler, bin-pack workloads, move fault-tolerant node pools to Spot, and consider the Vertical Pod Autoscaler.

Watch out: Set pod disruption budgets so autoscaling and Spot evictions do not break availability.

11 Right-Tier PaaS Databases

Idle-time savings

Move DTU to vCore where cheaper, consolidate small databases into elastic pools, and use the serverless (auto-pause) tier for spiky or intermittent workloads.

Watch out: Serverless resume adds a small cold-start delay — fine for intermittent, not for latency-critical.

12 Cut Egress & Data-Transfer Costs

Silent line item

Keep chatty services in the same region and zone, use Private Link/private endpoints, cache at the edge with Azure CDN/Front Door, and avoid unnecessary cross-region replication.

Watch out: Watch cross-region reads from analytics and backups — they add up quietly.

PILLAR 4

Govern & Sustain the Savings

The difference between a one-time cleanup and durable cost control.

13 Budgets, Tags & Azure Policy

Enables ownership

Enforce a tagging standard (owner, environment, cost-center) with Azure Policy, set budgets with alerts per subscription/resource group, and turn on cost anomaly detection to enable showback/chargeback.

Watch out: Tags are only useful if enforced — make them mandatory at resource creation.

14 Work Advisor & Cost Management

Free, ongoing

Azure Advisor already surfaces right-size, reservation, and idle-resource recommendations. Make a monthly FinOps review that works the Advisor + Cost Management backlog a routine.

Watch out: Do not action recommendations blindly — validate each against real usage patterns.

15 Modernize to Serverless

Idle time is free

Re-platform spiky workloads — event processing, scheduled jobs, uneven-traffic APIs — to Azure Functions and Container Apps (consumption) so you pay per execution.

Watch out: Very high-volume steady workloads can cost more on consumption — model before you move.

Your 30-Day FinOps Action Plan

A simple cadence to turn this cheat sheet into recovered spend — one focused week at a time.

Week 1 — See it

Turn on Cost Management + anomaly alerts. Tag your top subscriptions. Pull the Advisor cost recommendations. Identify your always-on baseline.

Week 2 — Cut waste

Delete orphaned disks/IPs/snapshots. Add auto-shutdown to all non-prod. Apply Blob lifecycle policies. Right-size the top 10 over-provisioned resources.

Week 3 — Commit

Buy Reserved Instances / a Savings Plan for the baseline. Apply Azure Hybrid Benefit. Move eligible batch work to Spot. Switch non-prod to Dev/Test pricing.

Week 4 — Sustain

Enable autoscale where capacity is static. Set budgets per team. Book the recurring monthly FinOps review. Pick one workload to modernize to serverless.

First Five Things to Check on Monday

Open Azure Cost Management and answer these. The gaps are your fastest wins.

- 1 What are my 10 most expensive resources this month, and is each one right-sized?
- 2 How much non-production compute is running right now, outside business hours?
- 3 What is my reservation / savings-plan coverage on always-on workloads?
- 4 Which resources have no owner or environment tag?
- 5 What is Azure Advisor recommending under Cost right now — and who owns actioning it?

Want us to find the 30% in your Azure bill?

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